STORY · LESSON 9

Who Ate the Cake?

A birthday cake disappears from the institute, and everyone is a suspect. Read the story, then read it from Mr. Ali's point of view.

- Report what people said with reporting verbs
- Use the right pattern after each verb
- Tell a funny mystery

1 The story

It was almost Mr. Ali's sixtieth birthday, and his students had planned a surprise. On Wednesday afternoon, Huda bought a big chocolate cake from the best bakery in town and hid it in the fridge in the teachers' room. The party was going to be on Thursday morning, before the first class, and everyone **promised to keep** it a secret.

On Thursday, Huda opened the fridge. The cake was gone. "Somebody has taken it!" she cried. Within minutes, the whole class was in the teachers' room, and everyone was looking at everyone else.

Omar looked at Adam. "You were here late last night," he said. Adam **denied going** anywhere near the fridge. "I was only printing the birthday card," he said. Then Sara **accused Omar of eating** it, because there was chocolate on his shirt. "You've been **caught red-handed**!" she said. Omar **admitted eating** chocolate, but only a chocolate bar from the shop. "I **refuse to be** blamed for a crime I didn't commit," he said dramatically.

Huda was close to tears. Sara, practical as always, **suggested checking** the security camera in the corridor. The guard **agreed to show** them the video, but he **warned them not to expect** much. "That camera is older than I am," he said.

They watched in silence. At 9:40 the night before, a figure walked into the teachers' room and came out carrying a large white box. The picture wasn't clear, but the walk was. Everyone knew that slow, careful walk. The thief **turned out** to be Mr. Ali himself.

Who Ate the Cake? (continued)

1 The story (continued)

At that moment, the door opened, and Mr. Ali came in, carrying the box. "Good morning," he said. "I found this in the fridge last night. There was no name on it, and the cleaners empty the fridge on Thursdays, so I took it home to keep it safe." Then he opened the box and read the words on top: Happy Birthday, Mr. Ali. He laughed so much that he had to sit down.

He **apologized for spoiling** the surprise, and the students **insisted on having** the party anyway. "Well," said Mr. Ali, "**don't judge a book by its cover**. I looked like a thief, and so did Omar." As for Omar, everyone agreed that he still owed them a chocolate bar.

2 Questions and answers

Answer fast. Short answers are fine.

1 **Whose birthday was it?**
Mr. Ali's. It was almost his sixtieth.

2 **Where did Huda hide the cake?**
In the fridge in the teachers' room.

3 **When was the party going to be?**
On Thursday morning, before the first class.

4 **What had everyone promised?**
To keep it a secret.

5 **What did Adam deny?**
Going anywhere near the fridge.

6 **Why did Sara accuse Omar?**
Because there was chocolate on his shirt.

7 **What did Omar admit?**
Eating a chocolate bar from the shop.

8 **What did Sara suggest?**
Checking the security camera in the corridor.

9 **What did the guard warn them?**
Not to expect much, because the camera was old.

10 **What did the video show?**
A figure carrying a large white box out of the teachers' room.

11 **Why did Mr. Ali take the box home?**
There was no name on it, and the cleaners empty the fridge on Thursdays.

12 **What did the students insist on?**
Having the party anyway.

Who Ate the Cake? (continued)

3 Point of view

Now Mr. Ali tells it.

MA

On Wednesday night, I stayed late to mark exams. Before I left, I opened the fridge and found a big white box with no name on it. The cleaners empty the fridge on Thursdays, so I decided to take it home and keep it safe. I didn't even look inside.

The next morning, I walked into the teachers' room with the box and found my whole class there. They looked at me as if I were a criminal, and poor Huda looked as if she had been crying.

Then I opened the box and read the words on the cake. I laughed until I had to sit down. I **apologized for spoiling** their surprise, and I **promised to look** inside every box before I take it home.

Later, Sara told me the whole story. Adam had **denied going** near the fridge, and Omar had been **accused of eating** the cake. Omar still **insists on telling** everyone that he is innocent. I believe him. Mostly.

4 What did you learn?

You learned reporting verbs.

When we report what people said, we often choose a verb that shows what they meant, a promise, a warning, or an apology. Each verb has its own pattern.

PATTERN	EXAMPLE
to do · promise, agree, refuse, offer	Everyone **promised to keep** it a secret.
someone **(not) to do** · warn, advise, ask, tell	He **warned them not to expect** much.
-ing · deny, admit, suggest	Adam **denied going** near the fridge.
someone **of / for -ing** · accuse, blame	Sara **accused Omar of eating** it.
for / on -ing · apologize for, insist on	He **apologized for spoiling** the surprise.

Who Ate the Cake? (continued)

4 What did you learn? (continued)

suggest + -ing
Sara suggested checking the camera. Not: suggested to check.

Negative: not before to or -ing
He warned them not to expect much. He admitted not knowing.

They say more than said
"It wasn't me!" He denied doing it. "I'll help." He offered to help.

QUESTIONS **What have you promised to do this week?**

I've promised to help my brother with his homework.

5 Idioms, proverbs and phrases

IDIOM
be caught red-handed
to be found while you are doing something wrong
Example: *The boy was caught red-handed with his hand in the cookie jar.*

PHRASE
turn out
to be found to be true in the end, often as a surprise
Example: *The exam turned out to be easier than we expected.*

PROVERB
Don't judge a book by its cover.
Don't decide what someone or something is like only from the way they look.
Example: *The restaurant looked old, but the food was wonderful. Don't judge a book by its cover.*

6 New words

bakery	a shop that makes and sells bread and cakes	**blamed**	said to be the person who did something wrong
dramatically	in a way that is meant to impress people, like an actor	**corridor**	a long, narrow passage inside a building
figure	the shape of a person you can't see clearly	**owed**	had to give something back to someone